

The unpopular and politically weak 90-year-old Palestinian leader struggles for a role in Gaza

CAIRO (AP) — [Palestinian President Mahmoud Abbas](#) turns 90 on Saturday, still holding authoritarian power in tiny pockets of the West Bank, but marginalized and weakened by Israel, deeply unpopular among Palestinians, and struggling for a say in a postwar Gaza Strip.

The world's second-oldest serving president — after Cameroon's 92-year-old Paul Biya — Abbas has been in office for 20 years, and for nearly the entire time has failed to hold elections. His weakness has left Palestinians leaderless, critics say, at a time when they face an existential crisis and hopes for establishing a Palestinian state, the centerpiece of Abbas' agenda, appear dimmer than ever.

Palestinians say [Israel's campaign against Hamas](#) that has decimated Gaza amounts to genocide. Israel denies the accusation and has tightened its lock on the West Bank, where Jewish settlements are expanding and [attacks by settlers](#) on Palestinians [are increasing](#). Right-wing allies of Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu are pressing for [outright annexation](#), a step that would doom any remaining possibility for statehood.

For now, the U.S. has bent to Israel's refusal to allow Abbas' Palestinian Authority to govern postwar Gaza. With no effective leader, critics fear Palestinians in the territory will be consigned to live under an international body dominated by Israel's allies, with little voice and no real path to statehood.